

Chapter Title: Revising Yoder's Theological Method

Book Title: Principalities and Powers

Book Subtitle: Revising John Howard Yoder's Sociological Theology

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Published by: The Lutterworth Press. (2013)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1cg4k49.10>

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Revising Yoder's Theological Method

THE POWERS' DYNAMIC AUTONOMIZATION never escapes the grip of providence. The fallen powers are created powers. As neither wholly good, nor wholly evil, the shape of the powers must be discerned. Yoder's theological method privileges a form of discernment rooted in the practical encounter between specific Christian communities and specific powers. Discernment is ultimately a function of mission. Theologians' contribution to this mission is limited, according to Yoder, yet indispensable for the discernment process. The theologian's gifts of linguistic analysis and scriptural and historical memory are useful because they facilitate a comparison of the powers with the way of Jesus. For Yoder, critical discernment of the powers is a comparative task.

Yoder's own work, therefore, concentrates on illuminating the way of Jesus as portrayed in scripture and comparing it to various points in Christian history. If the portrayal of the pacifist Jesus in *The Politics of Jesus* holds true, then a church that justifies war is obviously a fallen power. Christian discernment relies on accurate memories of Jesus, but it also relies on memories of how Christians in the past attempted to be faithful in their diverse settings. If the early church, St. Francis, the Anabaptists, and Martin Luther King Jr., could find ways to imitate Jesus' nonviolence in their times, then churches today can, too. Linguistic analysis is helpful at this point to expose the faulty logic behind justifications of deviance from the way of Jesus.

This work of discerning history and language is always contestable, and many critics are dissatisfied with Yoder's attempts. Several critics point to the insufficiency of his own theological language, given that he ignores both the need for metaphysical language to support the normativity of his ethics and the need for theological construction to specify his theological

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concepts. In other words, the metaphysical and constructive aspects of language cannot be overlooked in the discernment process. Other critics charge Yoder with a faulty memory: his interpretations of scripture and (church) history are tendentious, skewed to fit his theological agenda. Self-seeking and impatient, Yoder is an example of a fallen theological power, not a guide to discernment.

The present chapter suggests that Yoder can be a guide for discernment if aspects of his method are revised by Pierre Bourdieu's reflexive sociology. The chapter opens with an overview of Yoder's theological method and its critics, with special emphasis on his understanding of how to discern the powers. Next, resources in Bourdieu's sociology are examined, specifically his concepts of the epistemological break, relational object construction and confirmation, and reflexivity. The chapter concludes with a proposal for a Yoderian theology of the powers that is sociologically reflexive, perceptive of the symbolic, material, and spiritual dimensions of the powers, and inclusive of a rigorous empirical component.

Yoder's Theological Method

The first part of this section is a study of Yoder's comments on discerning the powers. He envisages the theology of the principalities and powers as a subtle mode of social criticism useful for the church's mission. Although he does not say how the powers are to be discerned, already in these writings it is clear that the basic methodology is comparative: contemporary powers, including the church, are judged by comparison to the way of Jesus as portrayed in scripture. This comparative method is elaborated in the second part of this section, through an overview of Yoder's understanding of theology as service to the church. The final part of this section examines the many complaints about Yoder's allegedly poor theological service.

Discerning the Powers: A Comparative Theology

Yoder regards the Pauline language of the principalities and powers as supplying the basic framework for Christian social discernment and critique. The Pauline authors continually correlate God's redemption of the world through Christ with the exposure of the continuing rebellion of the powers. Christian social criticism is based on the lordship of Christ over the powers, since this lordship requires a qualification of every competing claim to ultimacy. The structure of Christian criticism is therefore comparative: immanent claims to ultimacy are compared with Christ's ultimate status.

For Yoder, “discerning the spirits” (1 Cor 12:10) always involves close attention to who Jesus is. Although some Christians may be especially gifted hermeneuticists, the entire witness of the gifted congregation is necessary for an accurate perception of Christ (1 Cor 12, 14).¹ Scripture, moreover, is the primary witness to the congregation of Jesus’ identity. Yoder often takes Phil 2:1–11 as an adequate summary: Christ’s suffering humility results in his divine exaltation and reception of “the name that is above every name” (2:9).² The church that sees the humble Jesus is equipped to see the prideful powers. It is the powers’ failure to conform to Christ that gives away their fallenness.

This comparative logic is also evident in Berkhof’s *Christ and the Powers*. Of particular interest here is Berkhof’s exegesis of Col 2:15. Through the cross and resurrection Christ “disarmed the rulers [*archas*] and authorities [*exousias*] and made a public example of them, triumphing over them in it.” According to Berkhof, “it is precisely in the crucifixion that the true nature of the Powers has come to light.”³ Before the advent of Christ, the powers “were accepted as the most basic and ultimate realities, as the gods of the world.” But after the powers turn against God-in-Christ at the cross, there can be no illusions: “they are unmasked as false gods by their encounter with very God.” The shape of the fallen powers becomes clear in the light of Christ. Present discernment of the powers is then grounded in consideration of Christ’s life and work.⁴

Yoder makes the connection between Jesus and discernment explicit in *The Christian Witness to the State*. The “ground of Christian witness” and the “criteria for political judgment” have the same source. Christian witness has its purpose, form, and content in the lordship of the crucified and risen Christ.⁵ Moreover, “the Christian social critique finds its standards in the kingdom of God—for there are no other standards.”⁶ The state’s fallenness is apparent through the many ways in which it is not the kingdom, as seen especially in its use of violence to bring about order.⁷ At the same time, “the judgments of Christians who are well informed will often differ little in substance from the

1. See, e.g., Yoder, *FC*; *BP*, 47–70.

2. E.g., Yoder, *Preface*, 80–88, 104; *PJ*, 121–22; *PK*, 52; *HCPP*, 83, 89–95.

3. Berkhof, *C&P*, 38. The meaning of Christ’s “triumph” is the subject of chapters 5 and 6 below.

4. Cf. Berkhof, *C&P*, 47–64, on the church and the powers.

5. Yoder, *CWS*, 8–28, 35–44.

6. *Ibid.*, 39; see also his “Natural Law,” 22.

7. Yoder, *CWS*, 36–38, 74–83.

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intelligent judgment of other social critics.”⁸ Apart from his typical censure of state violence, Yoder’s focus in this work is on the positive political alternatives Christians might offer as part of their witness.⁹

Subsequent writings on the powers indicate a shift in Yoder’s understanding of Christian social critique. From “Jesus and Power” in *The Politics of Jesus* onwards, he highlights not just positive Christian alternatives, but also the uniqueness of Christian moral judgment. The theology of the principalities and powers aids in discerning both what is wrong with society, and what Christians should do about it. Although the latter is the topic of the following chapter below, it is worth noting again that, for Yoder, Jesus Christ is the criterion of political critique and construction. In *The Politics of Jesus*, Yoder argues that a critically informed review of the canonical text of Luke’s gospel shows the distinctiveness of Jesus’ teachings on violence, economics, and power.¹⁰ If the gospels communicate the “substance” of Christ’s politics, the theology of the principalities and powers convey its “form” by directing readers to issues of power and structure “in the sense in which these terms are used by modern thinkers in the social and political sciences” (136). Yoder therefore begins his treatment of the powers with a common sense analysis of the different ways modern people use the terms power and structure, and then asks if Paul’s language is “translatable into the concepts of modern social science” (138).

To answer this question, Yoder turns to recent European historical-critical studies of the Pauline texts, observing that these arose from a need to understand the “power of evil” during Nazism and the Cold War (139). Yet what marks the recent criticism is not an eisegetical leap to see modern problems in ancient texts, but careful attention to the meaning of the texts in the authors’ own age. Modern evils are illuminated by ancient insights. After detailing Berkhof’s exegesis of the powers passages, Yoder concludes that, “far from being archaic or meaningless, the ‘exousiology’ of the apostle, that is, his doctrine of the Powers, reveals itself to be a very refined analysis of the problems of society and history, far more refined than the other ways in which theologians have sought to describe the same realities in terms

8. Ibid., 35.

9. These alternatives are discussed in the following chapter, below.

10. Yoder, *PJ*, 11–13, defends his decision to attend mostly to the canonical shape of the New Testament, as his concern is precisely with the distance between the canon and current Christian ethics. He does not reject historical criticism, which he sees as providing confirmation for his arguments (e.g., 12n17, 41n35, 54–58, 72–75, 87–88, 139–49, 158–61). This overall approach is consistent with Yoder’s “biblical realism” (vii, x, 136), as explained below. Subsequent references to *PJ* in this and the following two paragraphs are in the text.

only of 'creation' or 'personality'" (143–44). Yoder now sees the theology of the powers as offering insight into social problems, not just alternatives. It is, he believes, superior to other theological options for social interpretation that, like Reformed "orders of creation" theology, do not "combine with such clarity and precision the simultaneous recognition of humankind's fallen condition and the simultaneous providential control." Nor do these other options account for the pervasiveness of religion and ideology in perpetuating the fall. Nor, crucially, are they focused on Jesus Christ—and, as mentioned, Philippians 2 provides a clear contrast between the dominion-seeking powers and Christ's voluntary subordination (145).

Because the Pauline language of the powers indicates an interpretation of all these elements (fall, providence, Christ) along social lines, Yoder sees it as affirming that "the New Testament provides [a] concept with which it would be possible to interpret the structures and the history of a secular society" (149–50). Secular criticism does not have the last word, as it does not account for the church as a community with special insight into social ills and their remedy.¹¹ This insight is rooted in the biblical cosmology as "a more adequate intellectual framework of the task of *social* discernment."¹² A similar argument appears at the end of *The Politics of Jesus*, where Yoder argues that the apocalyptic depiction of the victory of the suffering lamb has implications for our understandings of causation, community, and conflict.¹³ The risen Christ sheds his light on all things. For those with eyes to see, evil is unveiled as is good.¹⁴

In the Stone Lecture "Behold My Servant Shall Prosper," Yoder calls for discernment of the powers, since "some may be more fallen than others."¹⁵ The church does not possess *a priori* knowledge of the shape of the powers; its engagement of each hangs on the outcome of a discernment process. "The community," therefore, "will not ask whether to enter or to escape the realm of power, but what kinds of power are in conformity with the

11. Ibid., 152–53. Yoder is criticizing World Council of Churches studies that leave social analysis to secular critics.

12. Ibid., 156. Yoder mentions the extremely critical studies of French sociologist and theologian Jacques Ellul as exemplary modern appropriations of the powers language (157). He specifically names Ellul's studies of "money, the law, violence, and technology." By 1972 those studies would have included Ellul, *Money and Power*; *Technological Society*; *Theological Foundation of Law*; and *Violence*.

13. Yoder, *PJ*, 245–46.

14. Cf. Anderson, "Original Sin," for a Barthian account of sin as only intelligible in light of redemption.

15. Yoder, "Servant," 165.

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victory of the lamb.”¹⁶ Moral judgment of the powers involves a community focused on imitating Jesus. In Yoder’s first Stone Lecture he suggests that this focus—which he terms doxology—automatically places “any claim to glory or authority made on behalf of alternative value definitions” under question.¹⁷ This doxological hermeneutic is expanded in the essays derived from Yoder’s second lecture as an “apocalyptic critique” or “apocalyptic consciousness.”¹⁸ Biblical apocalyptic literature has been subjected to a variety of fanciful interpretations, but Yoder is convinced that, if readers let the texts speak for themselves, they can “help us to see things ‘as they really are.’”¹⁹ Christ’s lordship means that no human ruler “is the primary agent of divine movement in history.”²⁰ It means that the identification of moral righteousness with popularity or power is erroneous.²¹ It means that conceptions of society as a closed causal system that can be known (and manipulated) with certainty are fallacious.²² The fallenness of the powers is revealed in their resistance to the slain lamb who is risen as cosmic lord.

In this perspective, Yoder’s writings on the powers in his Warsaw Lectures and in “How H. Richard Niebuhr Reasoned” can be viewed as confrontations with competing modes of social criticism. The purpose of the lecture on “Early Christian Cosmology and Nonviolence” is to uncover “specific points at which we can see how [early Christian] thought was different from ours, and how this can help us to make sense of their witness and way in the world.”²³ The Pauline powers passages and, more generally, New Testament apocalyptic affirm the socio-political nature of redemption and the lack of correlation between social control and moral progress.²⁴ These insights help make sense of an earlier lecture, “The Science of Conflict,” in which Yoder critically engages social scientific accounts

16. Ibid., 167.

17. Yoder, *RP*, 123. He moves to critique the “realist” exchange of means for ends along these lines (124–25).

18. Yoder, “Armaments and Eschatology,” 53–54.

19. Ibid., 48, 52.

20. Ibid., 53.

21. Ibid., 54, 56, and “Ethics and Eschatology,” 123–24.

22. Yoder, “Armaments,” 54–55; “Ethics,” 122–23, 125–26. Cf. his essay on the sacraments in *RP*, 359–73, which is a significantly revised version of material from his fourth and fifth Stone Lectures. There Yoder depicts the sacramental community as internally and externally defined by dialogue—i.e., it does not accept a view of society as a closed causal system, but is constantly open to the future. This argument is a major theme of chapters 5 and 6 below.

23. Yoder, *Nonviolence*, 97.

24. Ibid., 102–3.

of human nature and social process.²⁵ Accounts that deny the possibility of faithfulness to the way of Jesus, or the efficacy of that way, are cast in doubt. For example, when psychological findings on the detrimental effects of passivity are used to argue against pacifism, Yoder counters that there is no reason nonviolence should be passive.²⁶ Studies of human aggression are sometimes read as justifications of the innateness of violence; but they can also be interpreted as highlighting the importance of direct conflict resolution in maintaining peaceable community.²⁷ In sum, faith in the lordship of Christ over the powers requires suspicion toward and reformulation of social scientific frameworks that overlook the power of suffering service.

Yoder takes a similar approach toward H. Richard Niebuhr's theological understanding of cultural transformation. Niebuhr dismisses interpretations of Jesus as the exemplary human or as cosmic lord as "radical."²⁸ His own Christology is moderated by a trinitarianism that views the Father and Holy Spirit as alternative moral sources.²⁹ Although this move appears to be faithfully "theocentric," Yoder views Niebuhr as surrendering Christian discernment to the ethical definitions of a given cultural mainstream.³⁰ Whatever this mainstream says is wrong with culture is wrong, and whatever it says is right is right—Jesus has nothing to contribute. The Pauline theology of the principalities and powers, on the other hand, encourages communal discernment of the powers in light of scripture's testimony to the work of Christ.³¹

Community, Language, and Memory

Yoder eschews methodological discussion that is not directly subordinate to the life of the church. In his essay "Walk and Word: The Alternatives to Methodologism," he argues that "the life of the community is prior to all possible methodological distillations."³² Ethical methods are pragmatic tools for moral discernment. There is no need for a unified methodology, but rather for "skills of mixing and matching [methods] according to the

25. Ibid., 63–72.

26. Ibid., 71–72.

27. Ibid., 67–68, 71.

28. Yoder, "HRN," 58–61 (on Niebuhr, *Christ and Culture*, 45–82).

29. Yoder, "HRN," 61–65.

30. Ibid., 66–67. Yoder later identifies theologies of cultural autonomy and relativism as similar moves that deny Christ as norm, and so disable discernment (77–82).

31. Ibid., 68–69, 71–77, 82–89 (esp. 85).

32. Yoder, *PWK*, 87.

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shape of a particular debate.”³³ Some debates call for a focus on duties, some on consequences, and others on virtues—and some on all three. The “wholeness of community culture” as it encounters concrete situations has priority over “the appetite for intellectual thoroughness,” and this goes for ethics as well as other theological disciplines.³⁴

Theologians are, consequentially, only relevant contributors to Christian mission insofar as they participate in the church’s encounter with the powers.³⁵ They are a resource in the discernment process, not the primary executives of that process.³⁶ In his essay “The Hermeneutics of Peoplehood: A Protestant Perspective,” Yoder writes of theologians (“scribes” and “teachers”) as being “agents” of the church’s practical reasoning. Among these he mentions “agents of direction” who prophetically “state and reinforce a vision of the place of the believing community in history, which vision locates moral reasoning.”³⁷ There are also “agents of linguistic self-consciousness” who help the church untangle itself from linguistic thickets that impede practice.³⁸ “Agents of memory” surface aspects of scripture and church history relevant to a problem at hand. Theologians thus have the linguistic tasks of cosmological construction and logical criticism, and the mnemonic tasks of recalling the church’s stories and scriptures. The following paragraphs outline Yoder’s own approach to each of these tasks.

Language: Cosmology and Critique

Little needs to be said here about Yoder’s prophetic cosmology given the focus of this thesis. Nevertheless, it is worth noting that he sees the purpose of cosmological constructions such as the theology of the principalities and powers as “locating” the church’s moral discernment.³⁹ Yoder does not seek

33. Ibid., 93.

34. Ibid., 92.

35. Although see Yoder, *PK*, 45, where he asks open-endedly about the prospects of an individual “internalizing” the discernment process in the absence of a functioning Christian community.

36. Yoder, *THW*, 121: “The ethicist is a servant of the communal identity, not its founder or its ruler.”

37. Yoder, *PK*, 29.

38. Ibid., 30–33. In addition to these three roles, Yoder discusses “agents of order or due process” (33–34). As Yoder describes this role in terms of an organizational facilitator, it will not be discussed here. Although there is no reason to think a theologian would be ineligible for such a role, it is not intrinsically linked to theological work, as the other agencies are to some degree.

39. Cf. Yoder’s comment that, biblically speaking, the audience of the prophet is

a systematic biblical “worldview,” but rather a general framework that can help churches understand their place in history as they go about interacting with various powers. Biblical cosmology is not speculative, but practical. Theologians imaginatively reconstruct contemporary language forms in order to convey the biblical cosmology, with full awareness of the theological risks involved.⁴⁰ The risk enables cultural transformation.

Yoder observes that the New Testament authors repeatedly adopted cosmological categories from their surrounding cultures, but “seized the categories, hammered them into other shapes, and turned the cosmology on its head, with Jesus both at the bottom, crucified as a common criminal, and at the top, preexistent Son and creator, and the church his instrument in today’s battle.”⁴¹ The Pauline use of powers language is one example, along with the logos Christology of the Johannine Prologue (John 1:1–14); the angelology of the book of Hebrews (2:8–9); the apocalypticism of Revelation (4:1–5:4); and the kenotic Christology of Philippians 2.⁴² Yoder writes of the process of cosmological adoption as a search for an “interworld transformational grammar” that faithfully translates the gospel into contemporary idioms.⁴³ Church history can be read as a catalogue of more or less faithful attempts at imitating the biblical model of gospel translation.⁴⁴ Even a non-Christian like Gandhi can be viewed as rearticulating the gospel within a Hindu cosmology.⁴⁵ The theology of the principalities and powers is, as seen above, an effort in translating the gospel into a secular social scientific cosmology. Such cosmological translation is central to the theologian’s linguistic task.

Yoder recognizes that technical aspects of theological practice require “professional” training and oversight.⁴⁶ But for him theology is more than a profession, it is a way of serving the body of Christ—of which most members are not professional theologians. Technical theological vocabulary then has its place, but theologians “must make sense in ordinary language.” Translating the gospel into contemporary cosmologies is one way to make sense.

the people of God, and not primarily the nations (CWS, 36).

40. Yoder, *PK*; *THW*, 109, 123.

41. Yoder, *PK*, 54.

42. *Ibid.*, 50–52. See also his *HCPP*, 69–88 (on John 1) and 89–95 (on Phil 2).

43. Yoder, *PK*, 56; cf. 54–59; *CWS*, 25; *PWK* 110–112.

44. E.g., the Anabaptists used Reformation-era biblicism, the Quakers used Enlightenment spirituality, and so on (Yoder, *CA*, 161–252).

45. Yoder, *Nonviolence*, 22–26; *WL*, 56–57. See also his *RP*, 260.

46. Yoder, *THW*, 125.

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Comprehensible prose and well-distributed publications is another.⁴⁷ Nevertheless, Yoder envisions the theological encounter with ordinary language as critical and not merely affirmative. Hence one of the theological agencies described above is that of “linguistic self-consciousness.” At the same time as theologians are to be sensitive to common language that communicates the gospel, they are to be alert for words and concepts that obscure it. As a theologian, Yoder is especially alert to “professional” theological language that enters the common parlance of the church with distorting effect—thus, his attack on Niebuhr’s *Christ and Culture*.

At the end of *Christian Witness to the State*, Yoder offers a formulation that could serve as the job description for an agent of linguistic self-consciousness: “It is normal for a newcomer to a debate which is already in process to accept the prevailing definitions of terms and choose one of the existing sides, whereas the wiser approach is to question the definitions.”⁴⁸ Yoder refers there to a debate current among American Mennonites in the 1950s over the implications of Reinhold Niebuhr’s thought.⁴⁹ Many Mennonites accepted Niebuhr’s designation of them as apolitical, arguing that the doctrine of nonresistance entails political and cultural “withdrawal.” Yoder’s response in *Christian Witness to the State* and elsewhere is to cast doubt on definitions of politics that exclude obedience to Christ as a possible political stance. Such definitional labor permeates his writings, for instance in treatments of “pacifism,”⁵⁰ “imago dei,”⁵¹ “responsibility,”⁵² “Trinity,”⁵³ “evangelical,”⁵⁴ “democracy,”⁵⁵ and so on. Yoder is also suspicious of dualisms that preclude obedience as an option, such as “inner versus outer,”⁵⁶ “grace versus works,”⁵⁷ or “Reformed versus Anabaptist social strategies.”⁵⁸ In each case the point is to uncover how common word usage can deceive

47. Yoder published numerous small church pamphlets, such as *Capital Punishment*, and spoke at church meetings around the world (see, e.g., the essays in *Revolutionary Christianity* and *OR*, and the “bible lectures” in *HCPP*).

48. Yoder, *CWS*, 90.

49. See Yoder, *Nevertheless*, 107–14.

50. *Ibid.*

51. Yoder, *WL*, 165–80.

52. E.g., Yoder, “Reinhold Niebuhr,” 112.

53. Yoder, “HRN,” 61–65; *Preface*, 203–4, 297–98.

54. Yoder, “Evangelical Dualism,” 450; *PK*, 54–55.

55. Yoder, *PK*, 151–55.

56. Yoder, “Evangelical Dualism,” 449–59.

57. Yoder, *PJ*, 212–27; see 103–9 for a further list of unhelpful dualisms.

58. Yoder, “Inadequate Typology.”

Christians into thinking that the way of Jesus is irrelevant or impossible.⁵⁹ Both transformative cosmological construction and definitional critique are central to Yoder's understanding of theological practice.

Memory: Scripture and History

In "Hermeneutics of Peoplehood," Yoder observes that there is only one time a Gospel writer depicts Jesus using the term "scribe" positively: "every scribe who becomes a disciple of the kingdom of heaven is like a householder who brings out from his storeroom things both new and old" (Matt 13:52).⁶⁰ The faithful scribe therefore "does not speak on his own, but as the servant of a community and of the communal memory." Moreover, the existence of a storehouse of memories indicates that the scribe's job is to select a memory or set of memories appropriate to a given issue. The community's memories are diverse, not univocal or interchangeable, and require regular review. "The scribe as practical moral reasoner does not judge or decide anything, but he (or she) remembers expertly, charismatically the store of memorable, identity-confirming acts of faithfulness praised and of failure repented."⁶¹ Yoder is again concerned with practical mixing and matching, not with a systematic framework for discernment.

For the scribe of the kingdom, Yoder suggests, "scripture is the collective scribal memory, the store *par excellence* of treasures new and old."⁶² In other writings, he designates his approach to recalling the treasures of scripture as "biblical realism."⁶³ This approach has its roots in a loose movement of biblical scholars from the 1950s and 1960s who pioneered a form of post-critical hermeneutics.⁶⁴ Biblical realists utilize all the tools of historical

59. Yoder's reliance on lists for investigating the various ways words are used bears further examination. See Belknap, *The List*, 8–11, for a brief history of lists, and Eco, *Infinity of Lists*, for a partial list of lists. Eco's ruminations on definition by a list of properties (versus definition by essence) are especially relevant to Yoder's method (200–243).

60. Yoder, *PK*, 30 (the translation is Yoder's).

61. *Ibid.*

62. *Ibid.*, 31.

63. Yoder, *PJ*, viii, x; "The Politics of Jesus Revisited," in *UNDA; THW*, 61, 100–101, 155–77, 178–91.

64. In his various references to the movement, Yoder names Markus Barth, John W. Bowman, John Bright, Oscar Cullmann, Edmund La B. Cherbonnier, Suzanne de Dietrich, Walter Eichrodt, Floyd Filson, Hendrik Kraemer, George Eldon Ladd, Paul Minear, Otto Piper, Gerhard von Rad, Adolf Schlatter, Claude Tresmontant, Hans-Reudi Weber, and G. Ernest Wright as the major figures. Yoder distinguishes it from the concurrent "biblical theology" movement (*THW*, 181–84). The eighteenth- and nineteenth-century German *heilsgeschichtlich* school, including the work of Johann

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criticism, but refuse the cynicism toward the texts with which those tools are often wielded.⁶⁵ Yoder takes the title and content of Paul S. Minear's book *The Eyes of Faith: A Study in the Biblical Point of View* as indicative of the main features of biblical realism.⁶⁶ Biblical realists search for "the biblical point of view," but without the assumption that a single timeless biblical theology or worldview exists. The unity of the biblical perspective is resistant to systematization, and to any other effort to domesticate it by shaping it to modern categories. Yoder reports that Minear imagined the biblical scholar as an archeologist opening a sarcophagus and finding a mummy, when suddenly the mummy reaches out and bends the tools of the archeologist.⁶⁷ The goal of biblical realism is similarly to let the Bible shape exegesis, in order to find "the message of the Bible on its own terms."⁶⁸

The "realism" of this approach is therefore its methodological conviction that critical tools can uncover the real message of the Bible.⁶⁹ Yoder accordingly accepts historical, literary, and sociological methods of biblical interpretation.⁷⁰ These methods, of course, have their origins in Enlightenment skepticism about biblical authority. Yoder praises skepticism as a corollary of Radical Reformation biblicism, which denies the presupposition of an "identity between what [the Bible] says and what we believe."⁷¹ Biblical realism nonetheless goes beyond Enlightenment objectivity with its realization that biblical authority is derivative of its ongoing function of constituting believing communities.⁷² Rather than drawing its authority from propositional infallibility or a pre- or proto-canonical history, the

Tobias Beck, Johann Georg Hamann, and Johann Christian Konrad van Hofmann, is an antecedent (159). More recent interpreters in the same spirit include Brevard Childs, Paul Ricoeur, and James Sanders (189).

65. Yoder, *THW*, 158.

66. *Ibid.*, 160–67.

67. Yoder, *THW*, 176. Minear does not use this image in *Eyes of Faith*, and Yoder does not report its source, but see *Eyes of Faith*, 3–5, on the impossibility of systematic objectivity in biblical studies, and 206–14, on how the biblical authors remember history as events of encounter with God.

68. This is the title of a lecture Yoder gave in 1964 to Mennonite students on biblical realism (*THW*, 155–77).

69. *Ibid.*, 167.

70. *Ibid.*, 124, 147. In the 1980s and 90s Yoder critically embraced aspects of René Girard's socio-anthropological interpretations of scripture. See Yoder, "Review: *The Scapegoat*"; "Twenty Years Later" in *UNDA*; *WL*, 29–41, 176–78; *You Have It Coming: Good Punishment. The Legitimate Social Function of Punitive Behavior*, in *UNDA*. These studies are anticipated by *HCPP*, 58–65.

71. Yoder, *THW*, 130.

72. *Ibid.*, 131, 153; see 94–119 on the canon.

scriptural canon is normative as a paradigmatic record of authentic norming efforts—a record that can “reach out” and judge contemporary efforts.⁷³ True hermeneutical objectivity enables the objectivity of the Bible to stand over against Christians today.

Biblical realism is also “realistic” in its (biblical) focus on historical events.⁷⁴ Yoder, following Minear, argues that the biblical point of view begins with the practical activities of God in creation, and so is unconcerned with questions of philosophical (mono)theism. “The Bible is not interested in this kind of truth, but only in those things which truly were done in a particular time and place by a particular divine initiative.”⁷⁵ The unity of the biblical point of view thus emerges from meditation on the disparate narratives, not from conceptual systematization.⁷⁶ Hence Yoder privileges an inductive hermeneutic that identifies structural homologies within the diverse biblical literature.⁷⁷ Inductive inquiry is complemented by an interpretative bias toward a “straightforward” reading of the biblical texts.⁷⁸ The events that matter are portrayed in the text as it stands, not in a history that allegedly exists prior to the texts.⁷⁹ Again, this confidence in the text is not primarily from an *a priori* faith in biblical authority—though that faith may be present too—but from observation of the way scripture works in the church.⁸⁰ The events recorded in scripture are the events that continue to form the church. Attention to these events takes priority for a hermeneutic sensitive to the real encounter between Bible and congregation.

The biblical realist scribe of the kingdom remembers God's interactions with humanity as reported in the Bible, recalling them as appropriate for a given situation and in such a way that their normative force is not blunted by modern concerns. As with the agent of linguistic self-consciousness, the purpose of this mnemonic task is largely critical. “The theologians’

73. Yoder, *THW*, 107–8, follows through on the logical implications of this view, and argues that the canon can never be closed. He mentions the *Didache* as a text that might be included in the canon. That said, he does not view the canon as totally flexible and open-ended: the records of Jesus' participation in the norming process, and of those of his closest followers, have priority. It is against those records that later norming processes are judged, and it is this paradigmatic nature of the canon that makes it a canon.

74. Yoder, *THW*, 167.

75. *Ibid.*, 167.

76. *Ibid.*, 145.

77. *Ibid.*, 142–47.

78. *Ibid.*, 145–47, 178–91.

79. *Ibid.*, 145; see 155–57 for Yoder's account of the failed search for the “Christ of history” behind the “Christ of faith” presented in the gospels.

80. *Ibid.*, 146–47. Yoder mentions Brevard Childs, George Lindbeck, and Alasdair MacIntyre as supporting a similar view on scriptural authority.

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task is more often to defend the text against a wrong claim to its authority than to affirm in some timeless and case-free way that it has authority.”⁸¹ All Christians have the ability to interpret scripture; the theologian’s special job is to make sure that in each instance scripture is allowed to speak for itself.

According to Yoder the church’s memories are of two kinds: “faithfulness praised and failure repented.”⁸² Within the Bible he discerns memories of both faithfulness and failure. These memories include the faithfulness of Abraham, the prophets, Jesus, and the apostles; and the failures of the Israelite monarchs, Ezra, and the opponents of Jesus and the prophets and apostles. This list suggests the inventiveness of Yoder’s own memory, as he goes against traditional readings to see a continuous lineage of failure that begins with the Israelites’ request for “a king to govern us, like other nations” (1 Sam 8:5).⁸³ Ezra did not restore the monarchy, but he adopted their logic of top-down, centralized administration backed by force, as did the powerful Jewish factions in Jesus’ day. Although antithetical to the way of Jesus, that logic grew within the church until it captured mainstream Christianity from Constantine until the present day.⁸⁴ Here as elsewhere, it is the way of Jesus that matters—events, even biblical events, are remembered as faithful or failures insofar as they align with Jesus Christ.⁸⁵

To recall these memories of post-apostolic “failure” suggests that the storehouse of the scribe of the kingdom is not limited to scripture, but includes the entirety of Jewish and Christian history. Yoder’s doctoral training was in Anabaptist church history and, although he quickly turned to theology and ethics, he remained active in historical scholarship through much of his life.⁸⁶ His approach to history is much the same as his approach to scripture, and he proposes a “doxological” historiography that “discern[s], down through the centuries, which historical developments can be welcomed as progress in light of the Rule of the Lamb and which as setbacks.”⁸⁷ Doxologi-

81. Yoder, *THW*, 84.

82. Yoder, *PK*, 30.

83. See Leithart, *A Son to Me*, for a “traditional,” typological reading of King David.

84. See chapter 3 above on Yoder’s critique of Christendom.

85. Yoder, *PK*, 37. Cf. Hays, *Moral Vision*, 248, on Yoder’s exemplary Christocentric hermeneutic. Yoder did not take the complement well (*THW*, 207–16).

86. Yoder’s contributions to historical scholarship mostly cease after the late 1970s, and by 1989 he considered himself only an “amateur” historian (see his essay “Amateur Historian”). Although it is true that he did not again embark on the kind of original historical research that characterized his dissertation, in 1989 he co-edited a collection of the writings of the sixteenth-century Anabaptist Balthasar Hubmaier (Pipkin and Yoder, eds. and trans., *Balthasar Hubmaier*). In the early 1990s he began to assemble a “History of Religiously Rooted Nonviolence” (in *UNDA*).

87. Yoder, *RP*, 132. See also his “Historiography as a Ministry to Renewal.”

cal historiography is regulated by the prophetic-apocalyptic cosmology of the lordship of Christ, and so interprets historical events, movements, and persons as more or less coherent with the way of Jesus. Elsewhere Yoder emphasizes that the critical perspective on history enabled by this cosmology is a particular gift of the Anabaptist and, more broadly, "restitutionist" or Free Church movements.⁸⁸ These groups refuse to assume that the way things are is the way things are meant to be, and offer a variety of narratives of how the church deviated from authentic discipleship. The purpose of these narratives is not primarily to stoke academic interest, but to offer insight into the church's present options for renewal. Free Church historiography is thus an exemplary mode of remembering for the sake of Christian mission.

Yoder's own contributions to such a doxological, Free Church historiography are numerous. His doctoral dissertation examines the formation of the Swiss Brethren—one of the first Anabaptist groups—as a process of differentiation from Huldrych Zwingli after he deferred the pace and form of reformation to the town council of Basel.⁸⁹ The existence of the Swiss Brethren indicates that the Reformation as a whole could have been otherwise. Yoder's narrative of Constantinianism as a gradual compromise with imperial power similarly suggests that discipleship was not impossible for third- and fourth-century Christians, but a lifestyle they willingly abandoned.⁹⁰ He states the underlying historiographical principle explicitly in the title of an essay on the Jewish-Christian schism: "It Did Not Have to Be."⁹¹ Historians should therefore become as familiar as possible with the options facing historical agents, as experienced by the agents themselves. Without denying the objectivity of causation, understanding the first-person experience of history as an open future achieved by real decisions is indispensable. Because the Christian doctrine of sin implies the freedom of choice for or against obedience, history cannot be wholly determined. If not, then it always could be different. Yoder's readings of history aim to demonstrate that discipleship is a latent possibility in every present—including our

88. Yoder, *PK*, 123–34; *JCSR*, 133–42.

89. Yoder, *ARSS*.

90. Yoder, *CA*, 42–74.

91. Yoder, *JCSR*, 43–44. Other examples of Yoder's doxological historiography include his readings of Jeremiah, Jesus, the early church, the Quakers, Tolstoy, Martin Luther King Jr., Gandhi, and the nonviolent people power movements of the 1980s. Each of these persons and movements affirm the possibility of discipleship and the contingency of disobedience. In the 1980s and 90s Yoder was especially interested in the sociologies of nonviolence and conflict resolution as contributions to this historiography. See *BP*, 8, 12; *CA*, 355–68; *Nonviolence*, 63–72; "The 'Power' of 'Nonviolence'" in *UNDA*; and the writings on René Girard listed in note 69 above.

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own. As a scribe of the kingdom, Yoder sought treasures new and old in the storehouse of scripture and church history.

Cosmological construction, linguistic self-awareness, biblical realist scripture interpretation, and doxological historiography are tasks of the church's process of moral discernment. Theology is a practical aid for the church as it responds to the good news of the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Because Christian mission is responsive across time and place, theology is an ad hoc affair. Theologians mix and match conceptual tools in order to supply the church with the right words and memories it needs to discern the path of discipleship in its diverse contexts. Often finding the right word or memory arises only after recognizing the wrong ones. Theology is an eminently critical practice, albeit one aimed at the positive goal of Christian faithfulness.

Yoder is under no illusion that theological insight and critique will be received by the church, much less by those outside the church. For the church, this is partially because theologians are not dominant and must yield to the other members of a congregation. Non-Christians are likewise discerning creatures whose decisions for or against Christ must be respected. In both cases Yoder counsels patience. However convinced a theologian, or any other Christian for that matter, may be of the rightness of his or her belief, the proper response to disagreement is never haste. In his essay "Patience' as Method in Moral Reasoning: Is an Ethic of Discipleship 'Absolute'?", Yoder outlines nineteen different forms patience might take.⁹² These include pedagogical patience with someone in a learning process; ecumenical and multicultural patience for persons formed differently than oneself; patience with one's own epistemological finitude; the patience of apocalyptic hope; and the patience of an outvoted minority. Practicing these and other forms of patience does not necessitate moral compromise or a weakening of conviction, but rather involves "accepting willingly and not just grudgingly" the differences of our conversation partners from ourselves.⁹³ Theologians guided by the conviction that Christ is lord of the cosmos can have the confidence to tarry with dissenting interlocutors within and without the ecclesial community. Theological patience enables and enlivens the discernment process. Patience is Yoder's method in moral reasoning.

92. Yoder, *PWK*, 114–19.

93. *Ibid.*, 117; cf. 125–30 for Yoder's response to those who charge him with ethical "absolutism."

Criticisms

Nevertheless, Yoder reports that an early reader of his essay on patience saw it as a self-justificatory apologia, as a claim that his position is "right."⁹⁴ To this criticism Yoder objects, first of all, that the critic obviously thought she was "right" in her evaluation of his work. There is no escape from the making of moral and intellectual judgments. More than that, however, Yoder insists that "the authorial 'I' here speaks for the coherence of a mode of moral discourse, a position, not for a person. I as the person John Yoder am not generous, or consistent, or transparent, or adequate."⁹⁵ He accepts, in other words, his personal failings as a patient theological servant of ecclesial moral discernment. A host of critics concur and point to several cases in which Yoder's language and memory evidence failure not faithfulness, haste not patience.

Language: Reductive Cosmology, Hasty Words

Other chapters of this thesis examine how Yoder's metaphysical reticence reduces spiritual, personal, and theological dimensions of human being. Yoder's reduction can be seen as at least in part a methodological error, and specifically as an overly restricted understanding of the linguistic aspects of theological labor. Although he develops a prophetic-apocalyptic cosmology centered on the principalities and powers, he does not investigate its metaphysical dimensions. No attempt is made at locating the powers within the activity of the triune God, and therefore the usefulness of this cosmology for "locating" ecclesial moral discernment is limited. Yoder connects cosmological vision to Christian worship, yet he leaves unaddressed "the task of investigating and clarifying the ontological grounds for the practice of doxology."⁹⁶ By failing to make his theological convictions clear, Yoder leaves the rationale behind his call to worship ambiguous. Cosmology and metaphysics are inseparable.

The effects of this cosmological problem are best seen in the confusion caused by Yoder's use of the word "God." When Yoder writes God, what

94. Ibid., 131.

95. Ibid., 131–32. "Patience' as Method in Moral Reasoning" was first printed in Hauweras et al., eds., *WC*, 24–42. An editorial note states that it was edited several times between 1982 and 1997 (24n1). It is difficult to read the above cited personal confession without recalling Yoder's own moral failings, and the public process of reconciliation he underwent in the 1990s. See Hauweras, *Hannah's Child*, 242–47, for the most complete published report of these events.

96. Dintaman, "Socio-Ecclesial Brushpile," 43.

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or who does he mean? How precisely is this God related to Jesus Christ? Because he did not explore the assumptions behind some of his basic theological terms, he muddles the process of moral discernment—do we follow the nonviolent Jesus, or the warrior God? Philip E. Stoltzfus suggests that Yoder's followers need to adopt a "theologically robust" form of conceptual construction to avoid internal contradictions that undermine faithful practice.⁹⁷ In other words, those who join debates over Yoder's cosmological pacifism must begin by questioning his definitions. They must begin by being more patient agents of linguistic self-awareness.

Memory: Slanted Scripture, Cynical Historiography

The results of Yoder's reduced cosmology and hasty words are on full display in his hermeneutical and historiographical practices. Ray Gingerich accuses Yoder of bringing an unexamined agenda to his interpretation of Old Testament holy war passages.⁹⁸ The need for those passages to cohere with the gospels overrules any critical appreciation of the frailty of the authors of the Torah. In the end, Torah and incarnation are left as competing sources of moral truth.⁹⁹ Gingerich sees Yoder's biblical realism as at fault here, for it "did not allow sufficient freedom to view scripture more dialogically, as the product of a fallible and faltering people of God—writings produced and preserved by communities in which power politics was at times more determinative than faithful prophecy and servanthood."¹⁰⁰ A constructive doctrine of God rooted in the nonviolence of Christ would allow for an alternative, critical reading of Israelite holy war. Other scholars raise similar concerns about Yoder's hermeneutical method. Richard B. Hays regards Yoder's reading of the New Testament *Haustafeln* passages in terms of "revolutionary subordination" as "apologetic wishful thinking."¹⁰¹ According to Earl Zimmerman, Yoder displays "an inordinate confidence in his ability to read the Bible straight, without paying too much attention to historical and hermeneutical issues."¹⁰² Mark Thiessen Nation furthermore wishes for deeper engagement with biblical scholarship.¹⁰³ It is notable that, aside

97. Stoltzfus, "Nonviolent Jesus," 41. See also Gingerich, "Yoder's God."

98. Gingerich, "Yoder's God," 427.

99. *Ibid.*, 429.

100. *Ibid.*, 432.

101. Hays, *Moral Vision*, 246. Cf. DeFerrari, "Review: *The Politics of Jesus*." Like Gingerich, DeFerrari faults biblical realism here.

102. Zimmerman, *Politics of Jesus*, 200.

103. Nation, *John Howard Yoder*, 198–99.

from a few references in the second edition of *The Politics of Jesus*, Yoder's interaction with contemporary biblical scholarship seems to have ceased in the 1960s. Perhaps Yoder considered his post-critical turn as an excuse to neglect rigorous hermeneutical and exegetical labor; but this is not the purpose of biblical realism as he presents it. Yet biblical realism or some other source seems to have encouraged him toward a less critical, even eisegetical interpretive practice.¹⁰⁴ Such practice is neither biblically realistic, nor does it serve the church in truth.

Gingerich also worries that "Yoder seems to have had an innate urge to sacralize the Hebrew worldview."¹⁰⁵ For Gingerich, this urge is evident in his unwillingness to criticize Israelite holy wars. Gingerich does not consider that Yoder is consistently critical of Israelite kingship, as well as of Ezra's post-exilic restoration of Temple authority. But he does point to a recurring theme in criticisms of Yoder's position: a split between a positive "Hebrew" and a negative "Greek" worldview. A. James Reimer first raised this issue in his essay "The Nature and Possibility of Mennonite Theology."¹⁰⁶ Reimer contends that Yoder, especially in *Preface to Theology*, accepts an Enlightenment bifurcation between the ethically-focused Hebrews and the speculative Greeks. This interpretation actually reads modern historicism into the Hebraic—but in contrast to moderns, both the ancient Hebrews and Greeks believed in "an absolutely transcendent spiritual reality."¹⁰⁷ Yoder excises the spiritual from the Bible and so misses what Reimer later calls the "existential-sacramental" aspects of Jesus' message.¹⁰⁸ Stanley Hauerwas and Alex Sider make a similar point in their editorial introduction to Yoder's *Preface to Theology*, as does P. Travis Kroeker in a 2005 essay.¹⁰⁹ Yoder's avoidance of philosophical inquiry haunts him, as he uncritically embraces an outdated dualism that distorts his reading of scripture.

104. Gingerich, "Yoder's God," 431–32, further blames Yoder's loyalty to the Mennonite church as causing him to skew scripture. For similar arguments, see Leithart, *Defending Constantine*, 317–19; Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 178.

105. Gingerich, "Yoder's God," 432.

106. Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 171–72.

107. *Ibid.*, 585n39.

108. Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 293. See also Swartley, "Jesus and Jubilee," 297, on Yoder's reading of Jesus' Jubilee proclamation in Luke 4. Swartley praises Yoder for recovering the ethical significance of this passage, but thinks he "short-changes" its personal and communal dimensions. Hays, *Moral Vision*, 246, and J. Zimmerman, "Yoder's Jesus and Economics," raise further questions about Yoder and Jubilee.

109. Hauerwas and Sider, "Introduction," in Yoder, *Preface*, 23–24; Kroeker, "Messianic Political Ethic," 147–48. Cf. Bourne, *Seek the Peace*, 93n54.

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A related concern for Reimer is that Yoder seems to exclude in advance any reading of scripture that supports church institutions.¹¹⁰ Reimer as well as Peter J. Leithart insist that Jesus' fulfillment of the Jewish law includes the civil law.¹¹¹ These critics and many others draw special attention to Yoder's interpretation of Jeremiah's call for the exiled Jews in Babylon to "seek the peace of the city" (Jer 29:7).¹¹² In spite of the vision of return to the land that immediately follows (29:10),¹¹³ Yoder regards this call as definitively establishing landless diaspora as the normative political shape of Judaism and Christianity. John C. Nugent, who defends the general features of Yoder's interpretation, still admits that it rests on a "needlessly pejorative reading of palestinocentric existence, the city of Jerusalem, and the return from exile."¹¹⁴ As mentioned, Yoder dismisses Israelite kingship and Ezra's restoration as distortions of the faithful politics of Abraham, the judges and prophets, and Jesus. Peter Ochs argues, however, that Yoder can only do so because he has generalized his reading of the gospels and is deaf to additional biblical themes. In doing so he draws "Jews and non-Anabaptist Christians into a sphere of already completed interpretive conclusions."¹¹⁵ As a scribe of the kingdom, Yoder's cursory inspection of the storehouse leads him to pass over many of its treasures. This is not a mere "methodological" problem. Hermeneutical haste precludes dialogue and does violence to the interlocutor.

Yoder's historiography has been subjected to a similar range of criticisms. Reimer warns his Mennonite readers against Yoder's example of "selectively . . . read[ing] the Bible and history and undervalu[ing] the positive mandate for institutional life found in the biblical narrative as well as in our own Anabaptist-Mennonite heritage."¹¹⁶ Critics have struggled with Yoder's reconstruction of Anabaptist origins since the publication of his dissertation in the 1960s. One influential response is from historian James M. Stayer. Although he acknowledges that Yoder's "writings establish him as the most effective polemicist among contemporary Mennonite thinkers,"

110. Reimer, "Positive Theology," 270.

111. Ibid., 245–73; Leithart, *Defending Constantine*, 133–36. See also Miller, "Footsteps of Marcion," 89–90.

112. Cartwright and Ochs in Yoder, *JCSR*, 29n68, 39–40, 158–59, 179, 203, 219, 222; Doerksen, *Beyond Suspicion*, 27, 46–50; Goldingay, *Israel's Gospel*, 764; Kissling, "Old Testament," 135–44; Leithart, *Defending Constantine*, 250n61, 293–97; Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 294; Schlabach, "Deuteronomic or Constantinian," 449–71.

113. Kissling suggests Daniel 9 as a more fitting support for Yoder's argument.

114. Nugent, "Biblical Warfare," 174.

115. Ochs in Yoder, *JCSR*, 159.

116. Reimer, "Positive Theology," 247.

he fears that the equation of the pacifist Swiss Brethren with normative Anabaptism “imposes on the disparate Anabaptist sects a consistency and a system which do not correspond to sixteenth-century realities.”¹¹⁷ Stayer identifies diversity among early Anabaptists in regards to the use of violence and civic authority to bring about reform. Even some of the Swiss Brethren were initially open to a “top down” reform given their alliance with Zwingli, who always saw reform as a cooperative effort with the Basel town council.¹¹⁸ Pacifism only became a broad Anabaptist imperative when survival was at stake.¹¹⁹ Yoder and other proponents of “Evangelical Anabaptism” read their theological ideals into the past at the expense of historical truthfulness.

For Yoder it is Stayer, rather, who fits the unsystematic “logic of events” into predetermined conceptual categories.¹²⁰ Stayer can only see two possible political stances, apolitical separatism and realpolitik—and the early Anabaptists were either one or the other. This framework precludes him from considering the possibility that sixteenth-century Anabaptists were mostly unconcerned with systematic political ethics, and were instead involved in a dialogical negotiation of their convictions. The seeds of normative Anabaptism are present from the start. But Hans-Jürgen Goertz responds that Yoder “appears to have missed the main point”—Stayer’s categories are based on rigorous empirical research. It is Yoder’s “systematized theological history which tends to abstract historical reality.”¹²¹ Anabaptist theologians do better to reflect on the objective findings of historians than to produce their own tendentious interpretations. Later Mennonite historians like C. Arnold

117. Stayer, *Anabaptists and the Sword*, 12–13. See also Stayer, Packull, and Depermann, “Monogenesis to Polygenesis”; Stayer, “Reflections and Retractions”; Stayer, “Separatist Church of the Majority.”

118. Stayer, *Anabaptists and the Sword*, 93. Stayer judges Yoder’s reading of Zwingli’s theology and politics as “willfully perverse,” with “brilliant polemic” masking serious historiographical distortion (61n35, 65n44, 101n18). On the Zwingli debate see, in order of appearance, Yoder, “Turning Point in the Zwinglian Reformation”; Hillerbrand, “Turning Point”; Walton, *Zwingli’s Theocracy*; Walton, “Was There a Turning Point of the Zwinglian Reformation?”; Yoder, “Evolution of the Zwinglian Reformation”; Harder, “Zwingli’s Reaction to the Schleithem Confession”; Snyder, “Birth and Evolution of Swiss Anabaptism,” 503–37.

119. Stayer, *Anabaptists and the Sword*, 117–29. He acknowledges that Conrad Grebel and Felix Mantz were opposed to the sword and government from an early date (95, 102–5, 111), but denies that their position was representative of Swiss Anabaptism before Schleithem.

120. Yoder, “Anabaptists and the Sword” Revisited.” Yoder is more sympathetic to Stayer here than to Clarence Bauman and Hans Hillerbrand, but still sees him as “theoretically committed to the systematic dualist definition of the question” (132).

121. Goertz, “History and Theology,” 183.

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Snyder are less convinced that history and theology can be so divided,¹²² but still see Yoder as unduly twisting the former for the sake of the latter.¹²³ Analogous criticisms have been raised about Yoder's readings of the Jewish-Christian schism,¹²⁴ Constantine,¹²⁵ the creeds,¹²⁶ just war theory,¹²⁷ and scholasticism.¹²⁸ As Paul G. Doerksen argues, Yoder has a tendency toward "lumping" movements together that leads him to ignore historical subtleties for sweeping themes.¹²⁹ Others observe that Yoder's historiography favors dualistic, "essentialized" alternatives that do no justice to complex positions: positions Yoder likes are equated with his idealized Anabaptism, and those he dislikes with Constantinianism. For instance, Jewish theologians Daniel Boyarin and Peter Ochs receive no compliment from Yoder's construal of a single normative line of pacifistic, diasporic Judaism stretching from Jeremiah through Jesus to Theodore Herzl. Yoder inadvertently adopts a form of supersessionism by eliminating those aspects of Judaism that do not conform to his understanding of Jesus and Anabaptism. Paul Martens worries that a similar logic is at work in Yoder's writings on Hindu, Protestant, and Roman Catholic nonviolent movements.¹³⁰

122. Recent attempts to synthesize a coherent Anabaptist theology in light of diverse origins include Finger, *Contemporary Anabaptist Theology*; Snyder, "Beyond Polygenesis"; and J. D. Weaver, *Becoming Anabaptist*. See also Paul Toews, "Mennonite Search for a Useable Past."

123. Snyder's contention is with Yoder's reading of Schleithem as a broadly normative, non-separatist Anabaptist document. Snyder, "Editor's Preface," in Yoder ARSS, xxxviii; "Influence of the Schleithem Articles," 323–44; "Revolution of the Common Man," 429.

124. Boyarin, "Judaism as a Free Church"; Cartwright and Ochs in Yoder, *JCSR*; A. E. Weaver, *States of Exile*, 25–40.

125. Leithart's arguments are discussed below. See also Doerksen, *Beyond Suspicion*, 141–48; Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 259–71; Sider, *History and Holiness*, 81–117.

126. Reimer, *Mennonites and Classical Theology*, 259–71; Kroeker, "Messianic Political Ethic," 152.

127. Doerksen, *Beyond Suspicion*, 206; Wiebe, "Evangelical Recognitions of Christ," 304–5.

128. Brubacher Kaethler, "Practice of Reading the Other," 47–54.

129. Doerksen, *Beyond Suspicion*, 27. Cf. Cartwright, "Sharing the House of God," 605, on Yoder's purely synchronic historiography.

130. Martens, Porter, and Werntz, "Introduction," in Yoder, *Nonviolence*, 11–12. Martens also suggests that Yoder threatens the integrity of the academic disciplines of biology, history, politics, and sociology by co-opting them for support of his particular reading of nonviolence. One assumes that Marten objects less to Yoder's use of various disciplines and figures to make an argument, and more to the reified way in which they are deployed.

Yoder's enemies fare no better. Peter J. Leithart has written an extensive defense of Constantine against Yoder, and his concerns resonate with the greater chorus of critics. On Leithart's reading, Constantine is an exemplar of Yoder's own theology of good governance.¹³¹ He ended Roman sacrificial practice; banned gladiatorial games; extended justice to the poor; increased religious tolerance; promoted Christian unity over his personal theological preferences; and (sometimes) subordinated imperial warmongering to ecclesial mission.¹³² Constantine was far from perfect, but he was a man like all of us slowly working out the implications of his salvation. Just before he died he laid aside the imperial purple, received baptism, and prepared to dedicate himself to the church.¹³³ Yoder is oblivious to all of this. His Anabaptist "fall of the church" narrative ahistorically reaches back to the early church and disavows the possibility of faithful contextual development.¹³⁴ He repudiates the primary historical source on Constantine, Eusebius of Caesarea, as captive to a "univocal" interpretation of history, but then sees that trait reproduced throughout the west up to Hegel—as if the reduction of fifteen hundred years of intellectual history to one word is not itself univocal.¹³⁵ This homogenizing historiography is quintessentially "Constantinian," as is Yoder's apparent conviction that rulers indeed do direct history: if Christ and the church are at the center of history, then why is Yoder so obsessed with Constantine?¹³⁶ His historiography is controlled neither by a proper apocalyptic vision, nor by a corresponding patience. The faithfulness and effectiveness of his contributions to Christian moral discernment are questionable.

Acknowledging criticism does not mean abandoning Yoder altogether, and his readings of Jesus, exile, church history, and Paul and the powers are still widely accepted as important, if incomplete, contributions.¹³⁷ His

131. Leithart, *Constantine*, 200–201.

132. *Ibid.*, 97–254.

133. *Ibid.*, 297–300.

134. *Ibid.*, 181–83, 315n20, 317–19. Leithart is also unconvinced by Yoder's reading of a "pacifist consensus" in the early church (256–78, 265–67). Leithart's outlines his own hermeneutical approach in *Deep Exegesis*.

135. Leithart, *Constantine*, 316n22, on Yoder, *FTN*, 70.

136. Leithart, *Constantine*, 317–21. Leithart also argues that Anabaptist primitivism is *literally* Constantinian insofar as it was Eusebius who generated the myth of the pristine church in order to call post-Constantinian Christians to obedience (319).

137. Blough, "Historical Roots"; Boyarin, "Judaism as a Free Church"; Cartwright and Ochs, "Editors' Introduction," in Yoder, *JCSR*, 1–29; Harink, "The Anabaptist and the Apostle"; Harink, *Paul among the Postliberals*, 105–49; Heilke, "Theological and Secular"; Hays, *Moral Vision*, 239–53; Kissling, "Old Testament," 130–35; Klassen, "Jesus and the Zealot Option"; Nugent, "Biblical Warfare Revisited"; Nugent, "Trial and Error"; Smith-Christopher, *Biblical Theology of Exile*, 6–15; Stassen, "Sermon on the

legendary “patience,” moreover, has become the focus of a growing body of literature.¹³⁸ Yet the criticisms cannot be ignored: Yoder’s linguistic omissions and faulty memory raise serious questions about his sociological theology. Several of Yoder’s critics maintain that Yoder’s theology continues to be a powerful tool for the church, but it needs to be made more consistent, if not subjected to constructive systematization.¹³⁹ As seen above, even the friendliest of critics call for greater cosmological, linguistic, hermeneutical, and historiographical coherence. Nonetheless, both its proponents and its critics see the lack of a grand system as central to Yoder’s legacy. Writing against Nancey Murphy’s systematic account of Yoder’s pacifism, Chris K. Huebner argues that it “fails to appreciate that Yoder’s ad hoc, nonsystematic way of operating is crucial to the very substance of his pacifist theological position.”¹⁴⁰ Murphy “cancels Yoder’s understanding of the priority of ecclesiology to epistemology by reasserting the Enlightenment dogma of epistemological primacy.”¹⁴¹ Instead of systems, we should accept Yoder’s nonsystematic approach and read his *oeuvre* “as a series of thick descriptions of social practices . . . that collectively define a particular stance or way of life called church.”¹⁴²

Whether or not Huebner is fair to Murphy’s effort,¹⁴³ some methodological adjustment is called for if the distorting infelicities of Yoder’s ap-

Plain”; Swartley, “Smelting for Gold”; A. E. Weaver, *States of Exile*; N. T. Wright, *Jesus and the Victory of God*, 294.

138. Blum, “Yoder’s Patience”; Brubacher Kaethler, “Practice of Reading the Other,” 57–60; Coles, *Beyond Gated Politics*, 109–38; Huebner, *Precarious Peace*, 115–32; Olenburger and Koontz, eds., *Mind Patient and Untamed*.

139. Doerksen, *Beyond Suspicion*, 26–27; Schlabach, “Anthology in Lieu of System”; Stoltzfus, “Nonviolent Jesus,” 38–42; Zimmerman, *Politics of Jesus*, 198.

140. Huebner, *Precarious Peace*, 107. See Murphy, “Yoder’s Systematic Defence of Christian Pacifism,” 45–68. Murphy endorses Yoder’s view that theology should not “be driven by any philosophical or systematic motivations,” but suggests that others can draw out the systematic implications of his thought to better defend it (45). She argues that the “hard core” of Yoder’s research project is: “the moral character of God is revealed in Jesus’ vulnerable enemy love and renunciation of dominion. Imitation of Jesus in this regard constitutes a *social ethic*” (48).

141. Huebner, *Precarious Peace*, 107.

142. *Ibid.*, 108.

143. For Murphy, viable intellectual systems are developing products of living communities. Internal to their structures as “research projects” is continuing flexibility and indeed vulnerability to the vicissitudes of lived ecclesial reality. Huebner’s objection may be that it is wrong to specify a hard core for Yoder’s project, but it is difficult not to see something like Murphy’s account operating behind the various “thick descriptions.” Murphy’s Lakatosian systemization of Yoder’s thought should be read in light of her appreciation of Alasdair MacIntyre’s epistemology. See her *Anglo-American Postmodernity*, 52–62. See also Schlabach’s argument that the effect of anti-foundationalism is not

proach are to be avoided. Put more bluntly, if Yoder's work is to continue to serve the church in the way he envisioned, its defects will have to be resolved, and that resolution entails some form of intellectual coherence. Huebner rightly demands that extensions of Yoder's thought take his (a)methodology seriously. For Yoder methodological mixing and matching is intrinsic to the vocation of the theologian, which is to privilege the demands of concrete moral situations faced by the church over intellectual systems. The issue is once again between adequate theological construction and faithful ethical service. The present chapter places Pierre Bourdieu's reflexive sociology in the methodological mix. Bourdieu offers resources for a more coherent and nuanced theological methodology that is rigorously attentive to concrete ecclesial realities.

Bourdieu's Reflexive Sociology

Like Yoder, Bourdieu is suspicious of methodological discussion and theoretical systemization that does not serve practical ends. "Those who push methodological concern to the point of obsession," he suggests, "are like Freud's patient who spent all his time cleaning his spectacles and never put them on."¹⁴⁴ Bourdieu's early methodological treatise, written with Jean-Claude Chamboredon and Jean-Claude Passeron for classes in sociological epistemology in the mid-1960s, is accordingly entitled *Le métier du sociologue* (translated as *The Craft of Sociology*).¹⁴⁵ The words *métier* and *craft* are meant to evoke a set of creative habits oriented toward production—a research habitus rather than a theory of research.¹⁴⁶ The sociological habitus Bourdieu and his co-authors propose requires, in short, a break from common sense language and concepts, systematic theoretical construction, and testing and revision of these constructions through empirical research. This "applied rationalism" is offered as an alternative to regnant positivist and theoreticist epistemologies and methodologies. The benefits of applied rationalism are identified for statistical and ethnographic methods, as well as for sociological science as a whole.

to rule out systems as such, but to point out their historical embeddedness. In that case systematizers and nonsystematizers are on a level playing field ("Anthology in Lieu of System," 308–9).

144. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 5.

145. For information on the production and context of CS, see Bourdieu's interview from 1988 that closes the English edition (247–59).

146. Bourdieu, *IRS*, 139, 222.

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Excerpts from exemplary philosophical and sociological texts are included in *The Craft of Sociology*, but Bourdieu later came to regret not simply offering a number of “master works” in the style of a medieval craftsman.¹⁴⁷ It was too easy for readers to treat the book as a new master theory instead of a prompt to masterful practice.¹⁴⁸ Even so, Bourdieu consistently affirms the arguments of *Craft*,¹⁴⁹ and it remains useful as a presentation of his methodology. The first part of this section accordingly summarizes *Craft*, taking note of later elaborations and modifications. Bourdieu does suggest that, were he to write the book again, he would place much greater emphasis on the closing comments on “the sociology of sociology.”¹⁵⁰ As this sociological reflexivity became a major preoccupation of Bourdieu’s later years, the second part of this section treats it in detail.

Applied Rationalism: The Epistemological Break

In *The Craft of Sociology*, Bourdieu and his co-authors describe their epistemology as falling between the extremes of idealism and realism: it is an “applied rationalism.”¹⁵¹ This middle ground “alone can yield the full truth of scientific practice by closely associating the ‘values of coherence’ and ‘fidelity to the real.’”¹⁵² The values of coherence are associated with idealists. In the sociological tradition, idealism is associated with the great theoretical system builders such as Talcott Parsons and Robert K. Merton.¹⁵³ For Bourdieu, their problem is precisely that they treat sociology as a tradition. They see their task as integrating past sociological theories into a whole, not

147. Bourdieu, CS, 256.

148. Cf. also the 1972 preface to the second French edition, where the authors note their refusal to turn the book into a programmatic pedagogical text, lest it be confused with a new, eternal methodological alternative.

149. See Schinkel, “Bourdieu’s Political Turn?,” 70. The most sustained accusation of methodological inconsistency comes from Mayer, “L’entretien selon Pierre Bourdieu,” who sees Bourdieu, WW, as a betrayal of the approach outlined in CS.

150. Bourdieu in Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 257.

151. Ibid., part 3.

152. Ibid., 66. In Wittgensteinian fashion, the authors name realism and idealism as a co-dependent “epistemological couple” which must be broken (66–67). However, there are several critics who suggest that he should embrace (critical) realism: Evens, “Logic of Practice”; Maton, “Epistemic Conditions”; Sayer, “Disinterested Judgment”; Vandenberg, “The Real is Relational.” And there are some who say he already does: Fowler, “Bourdieu’s ‘Understanding,’” 7–11; Outwaite, “Myth of Modernist Method.” As previously stated, the (Wittgensteinian) perspective taken in this thesis is that such debates are ultimately interminable and unhelpful.

153. Ibid., 15, 27.

performing detailed empirical studies that could give substance to their theories.¹⁵⁴ On the other side are the positivist realists, like Paul Lazerfeld, who likewise treat sociological theory as a tradition, but one to be rejected as a whole in favor of quantitative analysis. Yet without some coherent theory to make sense of their data—not to mention their research practices—there is no way to verify their findings.¹⁵⁵ As Bourdieu would put it later, “plagiarizing” Kant, “theory without empirical research is empty, empirical research without theory is blind.”¹⁵⁶

Applied rationalism, by contrast, is a dialectical approach that includes both theory construction and its testing through empirical research. The purpose of both sides of the dialectic is to effect an “epistemological break” from everyday, common sense knowledge of the social world.¹⁵⁷ Without the break, sociology simply affirms common sense—thereby putting its status as a social science in doubt. Scientific practice consists neither in the organization of theoretical speculations, nor in the compilation of random facts. For Bourdieu, tutored in the Bachelardian philosophy of science by Georges Canguilhem, the logic of science is a “logic of error.”¹⁵⁸ Scientific discovery occurs after the recognition that a phenomenon is not adequately accounted for by received understandings. A new hypothesis is formulated to account for the phenomenon, and that hypothesis is tested experimentally. If that hypothesis is found to account better for the phenomenon, it replaces the old understanding—but only until errors are identified in it and another hypothesis constructed to replace it. There can therefore never be a single timeless scientific method.¹⁵⁹ There can only be provisionally confirmed theories awaiting disconfirmation and supersession. Theories are heuristic tools that allow for a more or less adequate conception of the aspect of reality for which they were constructed. Theoretical construction, methodological review, and empirical research are not ends in themselves, but part of an epistemological break that

154. Ibid., CS, 26–29. In his interview on CS, Bourdieu says his primary “theoreticist” target was the Frankfurt school and its French epigone Lucien Goldmann (248). See also Bourdieu, *IRS*, 69.

155. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 29, 35–38, 63–64, 70–72. See also Bourdieu, *HA*, 31; *IRS*, 235–36.

156. Bourdieu, “Vive la crise!,” 774–75.

157. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 13.

158. Ibid., 3. This epistemological tradition was widely introduced into the English-speaking world by Kuhn's *Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, which drew from Alexandre Koyré in constructing the concept of a paradigm shift. On Bourdieu's relationship to Kuhn and the philosophy of science, see Callewaert, “Bourdieu, Critic of Foucault,” 85, and Fowler, “Autonomy, Reciprocity, and Science,” 105–6. The influence of Bachelard on Bourdieu's reflexive sociology cannot be overestimated.

159. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 4.

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aims to increase human knowledge of the real. Fidelity to the real is not realized without the values of coherence.

"*The preconstructed is everywhere*," as Bourdieu would put it in a later writing.¹⁶⁰ A Cartesian method of radically doubting common sense is necessary if sociology is to make the epistemological break consistently. In *The Craft of Sociology* and through his empirical studies, Bourdieu advocates for a unified social anthropology that would critically employ the best statistical and observational techniques to achieve the break and scientifically construct social facts.¹⁶¹ This language of social facts recalls Durkheim's "first and most basic rule" of sociological method: "*to consider social facts as things*."¹⁶² Considering social facts as things means considering them as independent of the individual human will; they in fact determine the will.¹⁶³ To identify them, the sociologist must discard her preconceptions of the social and investigate isolated, rigorously defined groups of phenomena.¹⁶⁴ Bourdieu and his co-authors interpret Durkheim as describing a scientifically productive way of seeing social phenomena and not as making an ontological statement.¹⁶⁵ Just as Galileo's view of physical entities as "a system of quantifiable relationships" birthed modern physics, and Saussure's distinction between *langue* and *parole* made the discipline of linguistics possible, so Durkheim's turn to constructed social facts is the sociological revolution.

Seeing the social world as a collection of social facts is to begin to see it as a system of relations. In *The Craft of Sociology*, Bourdieu describes analogical reasoning as the "principle of construction of the relations between relations."¹⁶⁶ The manner in which related scientific disciplines, such as linguistics, anthropology or biology, depict the relations between the objects they study is a useful starting point for developing sociological hypotheses. Analogically constructed hypothetical systems of relations can be developed into generalized models, and each model acts as a "miniature theory" that can be tested scientifically (52–55). Empirical sociological research is then a form of experimentation, "a permanent reminder of the reality principle"

160. Bourdieu, *IRS*, 235.

161. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, *CS*, 45; Bourdieu, "Participant Objectivation," 293. The original French title of *Invitation to Reflexive Sociology* is *Réponses: Pour une anthropologie réflexive*.

162. Durkheim, *Rules of Sociological Method*, 60.

163. *Ibid.*, 70. As discussed in chapter 2 above, Bourdieu's acceptance of the formation of the habitus by social fields does not lead him to embrace a total determinism.

164. Durkheim, *Rules of Sociological Method*, 75–85.

165. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, *CS*, 33–34.

166. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, *CS*, 50. In this and the following paragraph references to *CS* are in the text.

(61). The attempt to confirm a theory with data reveals flaws in the theory, which then allows for theoretical revision. The method is deductive (54) or, in the terms of Anglo-American philosophers of science, hypothetico-deductive.¹⁶⁷ Theory is important because only a systematic, coherent body of concepts can be falsified by experimentation; and experimentation is important, because only it can falsify theory (63–64).

Bourdieu recognizes that the view of the social world as a set of objective relations is not agreeable to those who see society primarily as a set of individuals consciously choosing their actions *de novo* at each moment. The “principle of non-consciousness” is indeed at the root of sociology, a methodological determinism that enables the construction of sociological objects (16). Because relations are fundamental, the sociologist must “reject all attempts to define the truth of a cultural phenomenon independently of the system of historical and social relations in which it is located” (19).

In order to construct the systems of relations, a number of research tools are helpful. Statistics, field observation, and questionnaires all contribute to the break from a common sense understanding of a phenomenon and its scientific reconstruction as a system of relations. But Bourdieu and his co-authors caution that each tool carries a theory about the nature of the social world and the way in which it can be known. In other words, each tool is more or less successful in effecting the break. Random statistical sampling, for instance, treats the social world as a group of acontextual individuals.¹⁶⁸ Bourdieu, who worked extensively with leading French mathematicians and statisticians in his research, prefers multivariate analysis, and especially multiple correspondence analysis, as it allows for the modeling of statistical relationships between all the relevant variables in complex social ecologies.¹⁶⁹ Likewise, Bourdieu recommends conversational interviews based on extensive prior observation over the dominant practice of non-directive interviews.¹⁷⁰ The artificiality of non-directive interviews can only produce “artefacts,” showing only how interviewees respond to questions and questioners foreign to their

167. See Murphy and Ellis, *Moral Nature*, 8–10, on Carl Hempel's hypothetico-deductive method.

168. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 39–40.

169. Ibid., 14, 40, 45n27, 46–47, 65, 254; Bourdieu, *IRS*, 96. Correspondence and multiple correspondence analyses are types of multivariate analysis that developed out of Jean-Paul Benzecri's work in the late 1960s. On Bourdieu's statistics, see Griller, “Return of the Subject?,” 8–10; Heinich, *Pourquoi Bourdieu*, 45–47; Lebaron, “Economic Models,” 555–58; Rouanet, Ackerman, and Le Roux, “L'analyse géométrique”; Sanders and Robson, “Quantifying Bourdieu”; Seibel, “Bourdieu et les statisticiens.”

170. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 41–46. On Bourdieu's interview method, see Griller, “Return of the Subject?,” 10–12; Mayer, “L'entretien selon Pierre Bourdieu.”

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social contexts. Encounters rooted in familiarity have a better chance of eliciting useful knowledge of interviewees' practices. Questionnaires suffer from similar problems, and the implications of each question, and especially the taxonomy of questions, should be carefully controlled.

Although the tools just discussed are highly technical, Bourdieu locates their foundations in the logical and lexical critique of common language analysis.¹⁷¹ Common sense understandings are expressed in words, and technical sociological tools are sophisticated means for exposing their assumptions and offering alternative constructions. Historical analysis of words and concepts likewise brings their theoretical resonances to the surface. Bourdieu did not emphasize historical tools in *Craft*, but they later became prominent in his research. "There is no more potent tool for rupture," he would write in the 1990s, "than the reconstruction of genesis."¹⁷² Words have histories. Forgetting them is to treat them as expressions of an unquestionable grasp on the world. For Bourdieu, the discipline of philosophy is the exemplar *par excellence* of the "forgetting or denial of history."¹⁷³ Sociologists are to break from philosophy with their radically doubting applied rationalism.

Reflexivity: Radical Doubt Radicalized

The Craft of Sociology concludes with a call for the "sociology of sociology": the path to a reliably preconception-free sociology is only through the application of sociological tools to sociology itself.¹⁷⁴ Over twenty years later, in Bourdieu's other sustained methodological reflection, *Invitation to Reflexive Sociology*, he would identify reflexivity as the hallmark of his sociology: "I believe that if the sociology I propose differs in any significant way from the other sociologies of the past and of the present, it is above all in that it *continually turns back onto itself the scientific weapons it produces*."¹⁷⁵ Descartes' radical doubt was insufficient, as it failed to question the social basis of the philosophical mode of thought.¹⁷⁶ As Bourdieu put it in *Pascalian*

171. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 14, 21–24.

172. Bourdieu, PR, 40. In CS, Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron do offer a brief history of positivism in French sociology (70–72).

173. Bourdieu, PM, 30–31.

174. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 69.

175. Bourdieu, IRS, 214.

176. Bourdieu, IRS, 241.

Meditations, his final review of and break from philosophical categories for the social world, radical doubt must be radicalized.¹⁷⁷

Even before *The Craft of Sociology*, Bourdieu had already begun to practice a kind of reflexivity. During his Algerian fieldwork he recognized that many of his basic intuitions about Kabyle culture had their origins in his rural upbringing in Béarn, in southwest France.¹⁷⁸ He therefore began to carry out simultaneous research in Béarn in order to convert those intuitions into disciplined tools for research. *The Logic of Practice*, perhaps Bourdieu's most advanced theoretical statement, reworks the conclusions of his Algerian studies, from *Outline of a Theory of Practice*, in view of his work in Béarn. It offers a reflexive theory of practice that accounts for its author's predisposition to conceive of practice in certain ways rather than others.

After leaving Algeria in the early 1960s, Bourdieu's reflexive discipline was turned to the education system that produced him. *Les Héritiers*, *The State Nobility* and his other educational studies all examine socio-economic and cultural forces behind academic success. The high point of this reflexivity came in *Homo Academicus*, where he studied correlations between the social and cultural backgrounds of French professors and their political views on the May 1968 student rebellion.¹⁷⁹ Although *The Inheritors* contributed to the student unrest, and he was in broad sympathy with Foucault and the other professors who supported the protests, Bourdieu himself did not man the barricades.¹⁸⁰ As Derek Robbins points out, Bourdieu well inhabits the category of an "oblate," defined in *Homo Academicus* as a career academic who, due to his low social origins, owes everything to the system.¹⁸¹ He was only "able to resist conservatism as a result of his capacity to understand his situation," i.e., through the reflexivity of works like *Homo Academicus*. Bourdieu states that the purpose of that book is "to trap *Homo Academicus*, supreme classifier among classifiers in the net of his own classifications."¹⁸² In doing so, he of course traps himself, and so increases his awareness of and control over the academic common sense that shapes his research.

A few years before writing *Homo Academicus*, Bourdieu published a short essay entitled "Sur la objectivation participante."¹⁸³ There he expands

177. Bourdieu, *PM*, 28–32.

178. Bourdieu, "Participant Objectivation," 288.

179. Bourdieu, *HA*, xi, portrays the book as the culmination of a reflexive project that began with his Béarn studies.

180. Schinkel, "Bourdieu's Political Turn?," 81; Swartz, "Critical Sociology," 792.

181. Robbins, "Epistemological 'Break,'" 39, on Bourdieu, *HA*, 291.

182. Bourdieu, *HA*, xi.

183. Bourdieu, "Sur l'objectivation participante," 67–69. See also his "Vive la crise!" 74; *IRS*, 260; "Participant Objectivation," 281–94.

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upon the comments in *The Craft of Sociology* about a form of ethnographic research that would account for the social gap between observer and observed better than the supposed neutrality of participant observation. The success of the effort to objectify the observed, he argued, depended on a parallel objectivation of the point of view of the observer.¹⁸⁴ Only participant objectivation can escape the false choice between the “mystified immersion” of participant observation and a mythic all-seeing objectivism. Although he does not use the phrase there, Bourdieu would return to participant objectivation as an interview methodology in *The Weight of the World*. In his closing essay on “Understanding,” he describes his research team’s construction of a method of “*active and methodical listening*” that evades symbolic violence as much as possible by employing interviewers who share a similar background to interviewees and who have studied that background thoroughly.¹⁸⁵ A “double socioanalysis” is made possible, as the researcher is implicated in her interviewees’ responses.¹⁸⁶ Although this method may seem highly subjective, distortions can be avoided so long as the sociologist is willing to practice the “permanent control of the point of view.”¹⁸⁷ Reflexive knowledge of the self is a condition of adequate knowledge of the other.

Elsewhere, Bourdieu discusses the history of sociology as another necessary component of the sociology of sociology.¹⁸⁸ Although he did not write an extensive history, at various points he addressed critically the origins of French sociology in philosophy and Christian humanism.¹⁸⁹ As mentioned, *Pascalian Meditations* is an especially trenchant break from sociology’s philosophical past.

Disciplinary history, participant objectivation, and study of one’s own familial and academic context, therefore, all serve as tools for sociological reflexivity. Each is a means for sociologists to break from the common sense that inhabits their research practices. Bourdieu’s identification of his sociology with this type of reflexivity, and his zealous advocacy for it, have struck some

184. Bourdieu, “Sur l’objectivation participante,” 67.

185. Bourdieu, *WW*, 609–10.

186. *Ibid.*, 612. Bourdieu often discussed his sociology, and especially sociological reflexivity, in therapeutic terms. See, e.g., Bourdieu, “Introduction à la socioanalyse”; *IRS*, 49–50, 62–74; *SSA*.

187. Bourdieu, *WW*, 625–26. Bourdieu is partly inspired and partly forewarned by the linguistic studies of William Labov, who used black Harlem youths as interviewers in his study of black Harlem dialect. According to Bourdieu, Labov did not subject his interviewers to rigorous training, nor had they objectified their context, leading to highly subjective interviews.

188. Bourdieu, *PR*, 39.

189. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, *CS*, 70–72, 251.

observers as beside the point. Reflexive review of one's practices is a built-in feature of human consciousness, some argue, and does not require special sociological tools.¹⁹⁰ Others maintain that Bourdieu is simply describing the basic research competence taught to every sociologist.¹⁹¹ Whatever the case may be, Bourdieu nowhere reviews systematically alternative conceptions of reflexivity in order to distinguish his own.¹⁹² He is not altogether reflexive about his concept of reflexivity. Nevertheless, he is clear about the sources of his passion for reflexivity: the special vulnerability of the sociologist and the potential fruitfulness of rigorous scientific reflexivity.

In *The Craft of Sociology*, Bourdieu and his co-authors warn that "the sociologist . . . is vulnerable to the illusion of immediate self-evidence or the temptation to unconsciously universalize particular experience when he forgets that he is the cultivated subject of a particular culture and fails to subordinate his practice to a continuous questioning of this relationship."¹⁹³ In particular, sociologists often overlook how their "class *ethos*" shapes their understanding of social reality, and how academic fads direct their research interests.¹⁹⁴ Because the object of sociology, society, is a constant subject of common debate, it is often very difficult for sociologists to separate themselves from spurious modes of social thought. But because sociology does, at times, carry scientific prestige, it becomes doubly difficult to escape common social sense when an audience demands "prophetic" vision about weighty topics such as "the future of civilization."¹⁹⁵ Sociologists must fortify themselves and refuse the social essences offered up by popular debates—even when these debates are supplied by past sociology. Concepts like "multiculturalism," "race," "globalization,"¹⁹⁶ "pure

190. Crossley, *Social Body*, 117; Lynch, "Against Reflexivity."

191. Griller, "Return of the Subject?," 12–14; Lynch, "Against Reflexivity," 34–35.

192. Jenkins, *Pierre Bourdieu*, 109. Typologies of reflexivity are offered by Holland, "Reflexivity"; Lash, "Modernization and Postmodernization," 258–59; Lynch, "Against Reflexivity," 27–34.

193. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, CS, 72.

194. *Ibid.*, 73–74. The authors want "to encourage a systematic prejudice against all fashionable ideas and to make an allergy to modishness a rule for the direction of the sociological mind."

195. *Ibid.*, 24–25.

196. These terms are disputed in Bourdieu, *Acts of Resistance*, 29–44; Bourdieu and Wacquant, "Cunning of Imperialist Reason." See Hanchard, "Acts of Misrecognition," for a vitriolic response to the latter.

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art,”¹⁹⁷ and even “reason”¹⁹⁸ and “the state”¹⁹⁹ must be subjected to socio-historical review.

Bourdieu notes that sociologists who supply and/or rely on official state statistics are especially prone to accepting official categories without criticism: “thought on the state (*pensée de l'État*) is always liable to be a state thought (*pensée d'État*).”²⁰⁰ This problem can be seen for instance with legally accepted definitions of “the family.”²⁰¹ Sociologists who do not at least question the identification of a family with heterosexual marriage, child-bearing, and a shared domicile are blind to the various moral and practical issues raised by homosexuality, divorce, and cohabitation. Moreover, any sociological treatment of the state must be willing to ask, “*what if the state was nothing but a word, upheld by collective belief?* A word which contributes to making us believe in the existence and unity of this scattered and divided ensemble of organs of rule which cabinets, ministries, departments, administrative directions, bureaus of this and that are.”²⁰² The reflexive sociologist gives up the certainties of the “illusory quest for an ontological foundation” and constructively explores the relational constitution of reality.²⁰³

Bourdieu promises great reward for those who endure on the path of reflexivity. Rather than being prey to the state and common sense, the reflexive sociologist has the opportunity to become “the *subject* of the problems she can pose about the social world”²⁰⁴ She can begin to think the social world for herself, instead of allowing the social world to think through her.²⁰⁵ Yet she cannot do it alone. “The gains from epistemological reflection cannot be really embodied in practice until the social conditions are established for epistemological control,” that is, for a fully reflexive scientific field.²⁰⁶ The sociology of sociology and of other disciplines enables a generalized conflict of the faculties to reign. Institutional inertia gives way and the scientific community moves “closer to the ideal city of scientists, in which, ideally, all the scientific communications required by science and

197. Bourdieu, “Pure Aesthetic.”

198. Bourdieu, *PM*, 93–127. The historicity of reason is treated further in the following two chapters below.

199. Bourdieu, *PR*, 36–56; “Reason of State.”

200. Bourdieu in Wacquant, “Ruling Class,” 40. Bourdieu names Durkheim as an obvious example of a “civil-servant sociologist (*sociologue-fonctionnaire*).”

201. Bourdieu, “Des familles sans nom”; “On the Family.”

202. Bourdieu in Wacquant, “Ruling Class,” 41.

203. Bourdieu, *PM*, 121.

204. Bourdieu, *IRS*, 240.

205. Bourdieu in Wacquant, “From Ruling Class,” 40.

206. Bourdieu, Chamboredon, and Passeron, *CS*, 74.

the progress of science, and only those, would be able to take place.”²⁰⁷ Reflexivity does not offer an absolute, position-less view of the social world, but it can produce scientific knowledge.²⁰⁸ The freedom gained by reflexive sociologists to know themselves and know the world is a kind of “collective conversion.”²⁰⁹ The liberated scientific community can act as a model for and goad to a free and rational political community—and this political goal, ultimately, is the purpose of Bourdieu's reflexive sociology.²¹⁰

Revising Yoder's Theological Method

Bourdieu's reflexive sociology is premised on the break from the common sense of and about the social world. Everyday practical reason is to be objectified and so purified by social science—especially when it is the scientist's own practical reason.²¹¹ One possible summary of the problems with Yoder's theological method is that he does not make the objectifying break. His language and memory are too indebted to Anabaptist common sense and he fails to question preconceived essences such as “Constantinianism,” “ethics,” “metaphysics,” and “the state.” Yet Yoder's theology is explicitly a servant of ecclesial processes of practical moral reasoning. Does this focus not put him and Bourdieu at irreconcilable odds?

The previous section concluded with the observation that the purpose of Bourdieu's reflexive sociology is political. Its goal is practical, but an improved practice stripped as far as possible of its tendencies to reproduce domination. Reflexive sociology aims to bring about a purified reason, but not a reason that escapes history and the realm of empirical practice: a pure practical reason. To the extent that Yoder's doxological theology is oriented toward a more faithful discipleship, it too can be viewed as a kind of purifying practical reason. The theologian's task within the church is not to leave it as it is, nor to affirm ecclesial common sense as always already adequate. As an agent of prophecy, linguistic self-consciousness, and memory, the theologian breaks from preconstructed theological concepts and critically constructs new ones suitable for a situation. Some of Yoder's corrective

207. Ibid., 76.

208. Bourdieu, *HA*, 31; *PM*, 118–22.

209. Bourdieu, *Les usages sociaux de la science*, 58. See also his *HA*, 15–16; *IRS*, 251–52; *WW*, 612–15; “Participant Objectivation,” 292.

210. The title of the second part of *IRS* is “The Purpose of Reflexivity,” and it contains a call for a “*Realpolitik* of reason” directed by reflexivity (174–201). The political nature of reflexivity is treated in the following two chapters below.

211. Bourdieu, *IRS*, 247.

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theological constructions are “the politics of Jesus,” “body politics,” and “the war of the lamb.” In each case, Yoder takes familiar ecclesial texts, language, history, and practices, and identifies new relations among them. These relations are not constructed haphazardly or without guiding hypotheses.

Although Yoder labels his approach as inductive, his explanation of his research process is deductive, as theological patterns arise in response to specific questions brought to texts and other theological data. When discussing, for instance, his discovery of a pattern among New Testament authors’ translated contemporary cosmological concepts, he does not say that the pattern occurred to him as he was combing through the scriptures at random. Rather, the pattern “fell into place as I was reading the New Testament *with a view to standard questions about how a small faith community can claim that its message is pertinent to a wider world*.”²¹² His interpretation of the Gospel of Luke in *The Politics of Jesus*, likewise, is not the result of a presuppositionless scouring of the text: “I propose to read the Gospel narrative with the constantly pressing question, ‘Is there here a social ethic?’ I shall, in other words, be testing a hypothesis that runs counter to the prevalent assumptions: the hypothesis that the ministry and the claims of Jesus are best understood as presenting to hearers and readers not the avoidance of political options, but one particular socio-political-ethical option.”²¹³ This method is not inductive. Yoder breaks from theological common sense by testing alternative hypotheses against scripture. He is engaged in a deductive process of “theory” construction, whether he likes it or not.²¹⁴

Recognition of the deductive process at work in Yoder’s research practice opens avenues for dialogue with Bourdieu’s reflexive sociology. Yoder’s break from common ecclesial reasoning mostly occurs through common language analysis and broad alternative readings of ecclesial history. As Leithart and many others contend, Yoder’s historiography requires far more precision if it is to be convincing. Sometimes his dualistic logical analysis seems to get in the way of textured interpretations of events. At this point

212. Yoder, *THW*, 143, emphasis added.

213. Yoder, *PJ*, 11.

214. One obvious point of divergence between Yoder and Bourdieu is their primary audience and object—the church for Yoder, the state for Bourdieu. This makes a difference insofar as Yoder is committed to the entire church, as is, having methodological input (in the “open meeting”), whereas Bourdieu’s democratic secular politics requires a process of education to prepare citizens for critical participation. Several of Bourdieu’s critics have accused him of sociological elitism at this point: Geldof, “Bourdieu and the Aesthetic Judgment of Kant,” 37; Griller, “Return of the Subject?,” 19–20; Lapeyronnie, “L’académisme radical”; Verdès-Leroux, *Le savant et la politique*. However, any alternative political program requires training and, as will be discussed in chapter 5 below, it is possible to see Yoder’s “ecclesial practices” as such a training program.

Bourdieu's dense, focused sociological investigations of various phenomena are a helpful model. The careful social histories he produced at the end of his life are likewise exemplary. Adopting the relational thinking at the heart of these studies would, furthermore, encourage the kind of multivocal logic sought by Peter Ochs and those concerned with Yoder's tendency to essentialize pluralistic movements as faithful or unfaithful to Jesus.

Relational thinking is, for Bourdieu, at once the principle of the break and of object construction. Yoder's primary concepts are often under-constructed. When he fails to break from Anabaptist common sense about Constantine, he fails to construct an historical object, "Constantinianism," that could be useful for his theological purposes. To critique the powers is to construct the powers. But what would such construction look like in light of Yoder's theology of the powers? The basic hypothesis of this theology is that the powers can be identified by contrast to the life of Jesus. This hypothesis postulates a relation between Jesus and the powers that is only made intelligible by postulating a further, unique relation between Jesus, God and God's Spirit. If Jesus does not have a unique relation to God and the Spirit, then it makes little sense to make him the standard against which the powers are judged. The God-Jesus-Spirit relation then has critical priority over the Jesus-powers relation, and cannot be dismissed as mere metaphysical speculation. Some minimal construction of trinitarian relations is necessary to ground a critique of the powers.²¹⁵ The God-Jesus-Spirit relation is social, but also more than social. It may not be possible to say much about ontological relations "within" the Trinity, but some acknowledgment of those relations is required if language about the powers is going to be theologically adequate. From a theological view, a power is incompletely constructed if its constituting relation to the triune God is left out. Moreover, recognition of that constituting relation enables genuine criticism of the powers, since it raises Jesus above them. The fallen powers are visible in light of the God-human Jesus Christ, not just the life of a first-century Jewish martyr.

Relational construction of the powers therefore must include all their dimensions: material, symbolic and spiritual. Yoder's approach to cosmological construction might be labeled as "prophetic materialism." He regards cosmology as fulfilling a prophetic function by offering a vision of a possible state of affairs that contrasts with a present state of affairs. In each case, the state of affairs identified is a material and a social reality, and not a spiritual plane or realm. Like early Marxism, Yoder's prophetic materialism pays little attention to the affective and cultural aspects of the present

215. See the first chapter of this thesis for one attempt at such a minimal construction.

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or anticipated state of affairs.²¹⁶ Like atheistic social theory in general, it pays little attention to actual or possible spiritual relations to the triune God. Bourdieu's symbolic materialism can only respond directly to the first problem; but preceding chapters have argued that it can nonetheless help theologians comprehend spiritual relations in such a way that enriches, not denigrates, an appreciation of material sociality.

Applied rationalism calls for empirical "testing" of the object—but how could this revised Yoderian methodology test its objects if they include metaphysical relations? For Yoder the majority of theological statements are about God's interactions with human beings within history. Metaphysical statements about God's trinitarian being may be necessary, but only as fences to keep us from saying the wrong things about Jesus.²¹⁷ Yoder may have underestimated the need for constructive description of those fences, namely, of the relationship between Jesus, the Father and the Spirit. But his ethico-political theology supplies later theologians with a large number of empirical statements that can be confirmed or disconfirmed through empirical study.²¹⁸

A nonreductive study of the principalities and powers might go as follows. First, construct the metaphysical "object," the unique relation between Jesus, the Father, and the Spirit. This construction demands further construction of the historical life of Jesus of Nazareth, such as Yoder provides in *The Politics of Jesus*. That construction can then be used to investigate the relations between the Father, creation, and Israel; the Spirit and the church; and so on. Further, the human Jesus exists in relation to fallen creation, which must be constructed in all its complexity—each variance in time and place, each power, is constructed in its particular relation to Jesus. Constructions of the historical Jesus and specific powers can of course be subjected to empirical scrutiny. With rare exceptions, Yoder's handling of empirical data is far from rigorous. Nor does he clarify the central metaphysical hypothesis required for his research project to make sense: Jesus enjoys a unique relation to the Father and the Spirit. That theory can only be partially tested by investigating the coherence between Jesus' life and interactions between YHWH and Israel, and the Spirit and the church—although systematic examination of the historical data in each case is crucial. At the heart of the

216. On early Marxism and its critics, see Hawthorn, *Enlightenment and Despair*, chapter 3, and Hughes, *Consciousness and Society*, 67–104.

217. Yoder, *Preface*, 223.

218. Cf. Murphy, *Anglo-American Postmodernity*, 159–65, on ecclesial discernment as equivalent to scientific theories of instrumentation. She argues that theological claims can be "tested" by communities for their consistency with scripture and their practical effects (164).

theory is just that, a theoretical statement about the being of God that is only indirectly testable by its coherence with associated objects. A realist constructivist theology would accept both the need for empirical confirmation of its objects and the irreducibility of its core theoretical statements.²¹⁹

Reflexive theologians will not only construct the powers without, but those “within” the church and themselves. This movement overlaps with Yoder’s notion of repentant historiography, but should be more critical of the social conditions of theological practice.²²⁰ Reflexivity would allow also for the incorporation of other academic disciplines into theology, without ignoring how the presuppositions of other disciplines may conflict with theological perspectives.²²¹ Bourdieu’s insistence that reflexivity be sociological, and not merely philosophical, is a salutary reminder here. Yoder’s sociological theology would, at the very least, seem to favor the prioritization of a critical theology-sociology dialogue.

Reflexive awareness of the contingent and compromised nature of theological practice should breed a deeper theological patience and humility. As with Bourdieu’s scientific city, theologians cannot obtain this level of reflexivity without help. The aim of reflexive theology is the production of the ecclesial city in which word and deed are related as intensely as possible to the life of the triune God. Each citizen of the ecclesial city has the task of receiving and constructing the divine gift of a free *polis*. Theologians’ critical tools aid the church, but they should also be receptive to the entire body of Christ. Those tools should be flexible as the hands of the church, and of the triune God, reach out to shape them. Reflexive theology occurs, therefore, in the relational reciprocity between theologians and their objects of research. Intense relating to God, church, and scripture is a central, not incidental, aspect of theological science. The break from Anabaptist common sense does not lead beyond Anabaptism, but to Anabaptist science.

Conclusion

This chapter has reviewed Yoder’s theological method in order to identify its major difficulties and explore revisionary resources from Bourdieu’s reflexive sociology. Yoder proposes a study of the powers that identifies their moral features by way of contrast to the way of Jesus. Within his larger

219. Ibid., 49–62.

220. For theology that draws on sociological tools for reflexive purposes, see Gill, *Social Context of Theology*; Gill, *Theology and Social Structure*; Smith, “Redeeming Critique”; Tanner, *Theories of Culture*; Ward, *Cultural Transformation*.

221. Milbank, *TST*.

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theological method, the theology of the principalities and powers is a type of prophetic cosmology, one of the linguistic tasks of the theologian. Other theological tasks include linguistic self-consciousness and scriptural and historical memory. Yoder emphasizes patient interaction with his various interlocutors in the face of specific issues. The theologian's goal is never to construct a master method that could suffice for all time, but to wield flexibly her constructive and critical linguistic and memory skills for the sake of the church's mission. Yoder is the first to admit that he is not the exemplar of theological patience. His critics agree, pointing to an insufficient constructive vocabulary and a memory that is too often self-serving. Bourdieu's applied rationalism gives Yoder a more critical framework for carrying out research, one in which the empirical dimensions of theological statements are subjected to rigorous confirmation. Moreover, Bourdieu's reflexivity can help Yoder's followers turn those research tools upon themselves, for the sake of a more patient, ecclesially-centered theological practice. That practice is the subject of the final two chapters.